Glass Negatives

Late 19th- early 20th century

Hall 4

Inv. no. A.16



Museum of Islamic Art, Cairo, c. 1881-1903, glass negative

Six glass negative plates from the Museum of Islamic Art's archival collection are on public display for the first time. Dating from the late 19th to early 20th century, they showcase wooden masterpieces from the collection, early shots of the museum interior, and a cityscape view of Islamic Cairo and the predecessor building that housed the museum's collection.



Self-Portrait with Camera, William W. Briley, 1880s - 1890s. Metropolitan Museum (Public domain).

What is a glass plate?

A glass plate is a highly detailed negative on a glass sheet coated with light-sensitive emulsion. These plates preceded film as the dominant medium for professional photography, and remained in popular use from the 1850s to the late 1920s. Offering more stability and detail over other formats of the time, such as paper and daguerreotypes, they allowed multiple prints to be produced from a single negative.

Why did they disappear?

Early film formats were not of very high quality and were intended mainly for amateur photography. However, advances in film technology and the introduction of large-format sheet film, coupled with their ease of use, gradually saw glass plates replaced by film in the early 20th century. Although they died out as a consumer format, their superior quality and stability meant they remained in use for certain specialised purposes, such as astrophotography, until the advent of digital photography at the end of the century.



Side by side of glass negative and photographic print, Cenotaph from the mosque of al-Husayn (549 AH / 1154 CE), Inv. No. 15025

Displayed alongside the negatives is a small selection from the museum's much larger archive of photographic prints documenting its wooden objects. Many were printed directly from these glass plates, whose fine detail captures clarity that later copies rarely match.

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